

CHAPTER 24 — The Index

The city appeared slowly.

Not as a skyline.

As traffic.

First the road widened. Then came warehouses, retail parks and orange cones arranged around roadworks that seemed old enough to have developed local government.

After that came buses.

More cars.

Rows of houses pressed closer together.

A hospital sign. A university sign. Three petrol stations within half a mile of each other, which Zoe decided meant the city had either too many cars or no confidence in any of them.

Rain followed them inland.

By half past four, the black hatchback had become one vehicle among thousands.

Zoe watched the lanes multiply through the windscreen. The paperback sat closed on her lap. She had read the same page four times since the coast road and could not have named a single character except the girl on the cover.

Elias took the outer ring road. He ignored the first city-centre turn, then the second.

"Where are we going?" Zoe asked.

"To buy a computer."

"You own computers."

"Not one I'm willing to connect that drive to."

"You said we weren't connecting it to a network."

"We're not."

"That wasn't what I asked."

Elias glanced at her.

She waited.

He had become better at noticing when the question contained another question.

"Clean machine," he said. "Old enough that we can pull the wireless card out. It only gets used for the drive."

"And if the drive kills it?"

"We lose a cheap computer."

"And if the computer does something to the drive?"

"It won't be allowed to."

"How?"

"Hardware blocker."

Zoe looked at him.

"That sounds like something people say five minutes before the expensive thing catches fire."

"Less dramatic than that."

"Most disappointing things are."

The wiper dragged another wet line across the glass.

Elias leaned left.

Zoe watched him do it.

"Wipers."

"I remember."

"You said we needed a new car."

"We need both."

"Good. I'm making a list."

She opened the notebook. Under the page containing Voss, Vale, Reyes and Sam, she turned to a clean sheet.

computer thing that stops computer breaking evidence blank drive She looked at Elias.

"Two blank drives."

She changed it.

two blank drives Then:

wipers

food

toothbrush

Elias looked over when traffic stopped at a red light.

"Toothbrush?"

"I left mine at the farmhouse."

"So did I."

"That seems unhygienic."

"Among our current problems, dental hygiene is performing surprisingly well."

"Not forever."

The light changed. They moved with traffic.

Zoe corrected the list to toothbrushes, then added socks.

"You bought socks yesterday."

"I am planning for a future."

"That's new."

She looked at him.

He kept his eyes on the road.

“Was that a joke?”

“No.”

“It was nearly a joke.”

“I apologise.”

“Don’t ruin it.”

The city swallowed them.

* * *

The computer shop occupied the ground floor of a former carpet warehouse between a plumbing supplier and a place that sold office chairs by the hundred.

A sign above the door promised:

BUSINESS IT - REFURBISHED - RECYCLED - DATA RECOVERY

Someone had crossed out RECYCLED on the lower window and written RESURRECTED in black marker.

Elias parked three streets away.

They approached on foot. Zoe carried the backpack.

The rain had weakened into the kind that did not look serious until every part of your clothing had become slightly wet.

Inside, the shop smelled of dust, cardboard and hot electronics. Shelves held rows of black laptops with white labels stuck to their lids.

A man behind the counter wore magnifying glasses on top of his head and ordinary glasses in front of his eyes.

He looked at Elias, then Zoe, then the backpack.

“What are you after?”

“Older business laptop,” Elias said. “No account setup. Removable

wireless card.”

The man frowned.

“Why?”

“I dislike updates.”

“First sensible thing anyone’s said in here all week.”

He came around the counter and began pulling machines from a shelf.

The one Elias chose had thick black casing, a scratched lid and a keyboard made shiny by years of other people’s fingers.

“Battery’s mediocre,” the man said.

“Fine.”

“Screen’s good.”

“Fine.”

“Eight gig.”

“Fine.”

The man looked at Zoe.

“He’s a terrible customer.”

“I noticed.”

Elias ignored both of them.

“I need a write blocker. USB.”

The man’s expression changed. Not alarm. Interest.

He reached beneath the counter and produced a small metal device with two ports and a physical switch.

Zoe moved closer.

“What does it actually do?”

“Lets the computer read a drive without sending changes back.”

“So if the computer does something stupid?”

“It does something stupid to itself.”

Zoe looked at Elias.

“That explanation was better.”

“I was driving.”

“Excuses.”

The shopkeeper smiled and added two sealed external drives, a screwdriver set, adapter cables and, after Zoe objected to the laptop’s touchpad, a wired mouse.

Elias paid in cash.

The man counted it twice and did not ask for a name.

At the door, Zoe stopped beside a basket of cheap wired headphones. She picked up one packet, then put it back.

Elias noticed.

“Do you want them?”

“I don’t have anything to plug them into.”

The absence of her phone entered the conversation without either of them naming it.

“Later,” Elias said.

Zoe adjusted the backpack strap.

“Later is becoming very busy.”

This time he only opened the door for her.

* * *

The hotel was not safe.

Elias told her that before they entered.

Zoe looked up at the four-storey brick building between a closed

pharmacy and a restaurant with plastic menus in the window.

“Comforting.”

“It’s a room.”

“With locks.”

“And beds.”

“Sounds like a refuge.”

“We’re not staying long enough to make it one.”

A taxi stopped outside. A woman carrying two supermarket bags got out and argued with the driver about fifty pence. Two men in work clothes smoked beneath an awning. A child pressed both hands to an upstairs window while someone behind him tried to pull the curtain closed.

Ordinary.

Visible.

Temporary.

Zoe understood the difference. She did not entirely like it.

“Convenient definition.”

“Probably.”

They left the hatchback in a public multi-storey several streets away and entered the hotel separately.

Elias paid cash for one room.

The receptionist asked whether they wanted breakfast.

Elias said no.

Zoe said yes.

The receptionist looked between them.

“Breakfast finishes at nine thirty.”

Zoe looked at Elias.

"We'll be gone," he said.

"Then no."

Room 314 had two narrow beds, a desk, a television fixed to the wall and a kettle that looked older than the carpet.

Zoe checked the bathroom and beneath both beds. Elias checked the window and door.

Neither commented on the other.

The backpack went on Zoe's bed.

Her bed.

Elias placed the computer-shop bags on the desk.

"One night."

"You keep announcing that like the room might misunderstand."

"It has poor judgement."

Zoe looked down at the red-and-brown carpet.

"Clearly."

Elias almost smiled.

Then he looked at the equipment and the room changed.

Not physically.

Purpose did that.

The road had ended.

The drive had arrived.

* * *

They did not touch it immediately.

Zoe made sure of that.

"Explain first."

Elias stopped unpacking the screwdriver set.

"The original stays untouched," he said. "We make a copy. We work from the copy. If anything tries to change the original, we stop."

"How do we know it can't?"

He held up the metal blocker.

"We test this before the drive goes near it."

"Twice."

"Once is enough."

"Twice."

He looked at her.

"Twice."

Zoe folded her arms.

"Three times."

He sighed through his nose.

"You negotiated badly."

"You agreed too fast."

They started with the laptop. Elias removed the wireless card and placed it on the desk where Zoe could see it. He started the machine without the archive attached. He checked the blank drives, then tested the blocker.

Once.

Twice.

Zoe made him do it a third time anyway.

Only then did she open the backpack.

The folder came out first. Then the paperback. Then the black drive,

still wrapped in cloth.

She placed it on the bed.

Elias looked at it and did not move.

Zoe realised what he was waiting for.

"You can pick it up."

He did.

Because he had waited, the handover felt like a choice rather than a surrender.

He turned the drive over.

"One terabyte."

"The shop man guessed right."

"He has seen ordinary sins."

"Apparently."

Zoe opened the numbered folder.

Her photograph stared back at her.

Six or seven years old. Two plaits. Laughing at something outside the frame.

She had learned to look at the picture without expecting memory to arrive. It still did not.

Below it sat the number.

A17-04221

For years it had existed without meaning. Then, for days, it had meant that somebody had known her before Helen and Brian.

Now it was going to become a search.

Zoe copied it into the notebook.

Elias connected the drive through the blocker.

A storage device appeared on the old laptop.

Two sections.

One large and unreadable.

One much smaller.

Nothing flashed. No alarm went off. No lines of code raced across the screen like films had promised.

Elias did not open either section.

He started the copy.

Estimated time: 1 hour 47 minutes.

Zoe stared.

"That's offensive."

"It's a large drive."

The number changed.

1 hour 53 minutes.

She pointed.

"It got worse."

"Never encourage a progress estimate."

"What do we do for two hours?"

"Eat."

She looked at him.

"Best lesson so far."

* * *

They bought food from the restaurant downstairs without using the hotel phone.

Back in the room, the copy had reached sixteen percent.

Zoe ate cross-legged on the bed with the backpack beside her and the drive visible on the desk.

She kept looking at the cable.

After more than two weeks of carrying the thing through cars, cottages, fields, buses and gunfire, seeing it plugged into something felt more dangerous than any of those things.

The paperback lay open beside her.

She tried again.

The girl in the story had discovered that a teacher was stealing exam papers and selling the answers to parents.

Zoe read six pages, then checked the progress bar.

Twenty-three percent.

She read another page.

Twenty-four.

"This book has a criminal conspiracy," she said.

Elias sat on the floor against the second bed, eating from a cardboard container.

"How serious?"

"Stolen exam papers."

"Terrifying."

"The head teacher may be involved."

"Then we should leave."

"She has two best friends helping."

"Unprofessional."

"They have bicycles."

Elias considered that.

"That changes things."

Zoe looked at him.

"You are mocking my book."

"I'm assessing resources."

She smiled before she could stop herself, then hid it behind another page of the book.

Outside, traffic moved through the city. A siren passed twice. Someone laughed too loudly in the corridor. A door slammed.

The room remained what Elias had said it was.

A room.

Enough.

At fifty-eight percent, Zoe fell asleep without deciding to.

When she opened her eyes, Elias was saying her name from the other side of the room.

"Copy's finished."

She sat up quickly.

"How long?"

"Twenty minutes."

"You should've woken me."

"You were asleep."

Zoe stared at him.

Elias set down his mug.

"Next time I wake you."

That was better.

He had made tea. Hers had gone cold.

She drank it anyway.

* * *

The original went back into the backpack first.

Only then did they turn to the working copy.

The screen showed the same two sections. Most of the drive remained encrypted, a dark block with no readable folders or filenames.

Beside it sat a much smaller catalogue.

Elias leaned closer.

“Index.”

The word settled differently.

A drive was a thing you carried.

An index told you where things were.

“Open it.”

Elias looked at her.

Zoe hated that she was not sure.

She looked at the backpack, then at the folder beside her.

“Open the copy.”

The catalogue contained no photographs. No names. No letters. No convenient document explaining everything.

Just small database files and an export created the morning Zoe escaped Cain’s house.

When the table opened, hundreds of rows filled the screen.

Numbers.

Dates.

Short codes.

More numbers.

Zoe stared at it.

"That's horrible."

"Because you can't read it?"

"Because somebody can."

Elias moved his hands away from the keyboard.

Zoe leaned closer. Most of the headings meant nothing to her. Roots. Current IDs. Routes. Accounts. Actions.

One thing did not need translating.

She opened the search box herself and typed:

A17-04221

One result appeared.

Her number sat at the beginning of the row.

Beside it was another identifier.

P06-11803

Then a route code.

Then:

AC019

Zoe opened the paper folder and found the transfer page. The date matched the placement period. On the payment record, beside an amount she had already seen, sat the same account code.

AC019.

"Mac," she said.

The word came out before she could stop it.

Then she shook her head.

"No. Mac's name is in the folder. This is just the same code."

Elias said nothing.

He did not need to.

Zoe wrote:

AC019 - probably Mac. prove it

The row had more beneath it.

She clicked.

The first looked like the placement she already knew about.

The second contained one word she understood immediately.

MONITOR

Zoe's mouth went dry.

"What does that mean?"

"I know what the word means," Elias said. "I don't know what they meant by it."

She hated the answer because it was careful and because it was right.

The status beside it said ACTIVE.

The record stretched back years.

Zoe looked from the screen to the old photograph.

"That was there the whole time?"

"Looks like it."

"While I was at home. School. Everything."

Elias did not answer.

The silence was enough.

The next line was dated Monday.

The day before the van.

RECOVER

Zoe read it once.

Then again.

“That’s what Voss called the job.”

Elias shifted closer to the screen.

Zoe did not look at him.

“They called taking me recovery.”

The word sat there in capital letters as if it were ordinary.

MONITOR had been active for years.

Then Monday.

RECOVER.

Zoe opened the notebook and wrote only:

WHAT CHANGED ON MONDAY?

The last line had been created Friday morning.

The day she escaped Cain’s house.

EXCEPTION

Status: UNRESOLVED.

Zoe stared at that one longer.

“Me getting out?”

“Could be.”

She wrote:

EXCEPTION - Friday. Me?

* * *

Zoe went back to AC019.

"Search the code."

Elias looked at her.

"Not Mac," she said before he could speak. "The code."

He slid the mouse towards her.

"Your search."

Sixty-three records came back.

Zoe's first thought was children.

It arrived so quickly it frightened her.

Then she looked again.

Sixty-three records meant sixty-three actions. Not sixty-three children. She was getting better at catching herself before a guess turned into a fact.

Elias showed her how to group the results by the first identifier.

Twenty-three different root numbers remained.

Zoe counted them anyway.

"Twenty-three kids?"

The words were already out.

She grimaced.

"No. Twenty-three numbers."

"For now," Elias said.

She wrote:

23 numbers. DON'T CALL THEM KIDS YET.

Some of the twenty-three had one action beside them. Others had several. Some ended CLOSED. Others UNRESOLVED or TRANSFERRED.

Then Zoe saw one that said:

DECEASED

Her hand stopped on the mouse.

The room went quiet.

"Could be the case status," Elias said. "Or the person. We don't know."

Zoe looked at the root number beside it.

It began the same way hers did.

A17-.

Different ending.

"They aren't names," she said.

Elias looked at the screen.

"No."

"Even for that."

He did not try to make it better.

Zoe moved away from the row.

Not because she wanted to forget it.

Because she was not going to let one word invent a person she did not know.

She scrolled back to her own entry.

The route code kept appearing.

N4-7

Another recent action used:

E2-4

"Those mean anything to you?" she asked.

Elias shook his head.

Zoe thought of the folded intermediary sheet Voss and Vale had given them.

"Maybe they know."

Elias's expression tightened.

"Maybe."

"You have their sheet."

He pulled it from his coat. It had survived the rain, the cafe and the delivery van. One corner still carried a faint smear of mayonnaise.

Zoe pointed.

"Evidence."

"Condiment."

"Contaminated evidence."

"It was never evidence."

"It has names."

"Information."

"You are very particular."

"It keeps mistakes small."

She read the sheet again.

Companies. Addresses. Intermediaries. People they might eventually verify.

None of those names appeared in the index. Only codes.

"That's annoying."

"Useful too."

"How?"

"If everything matched on the first night, I'd assume we were being shown what somebody wanted us to see."

Zoe frowned at the screen.

She had not thought of that.

"I still prefer annoying less."

"Most people do."

She tapped N4-7 with the end of the pen.

"We ask Voss and Vale when we can do it without using the channel Mac already found."

Elias folded the sheet again.

"Then that's tomorrow's problem."

"You keep giving tomorrow work."

"Tomorrow hasn't complained."

"Yet."

* * *

It was nearly eleven when Elias closed the AC019 search.

He left the index open.

"Enough."

Zoe looked at the clock, then at him.

"We just got inside."

"We got inside the catalogue. The encrypted part is still closed."

"So this barely counts."

"It counts enough to make us dangerous to ourselves if we keep guessing."

That irritated her more because it sounded true.

She looked at the rows again.

Twenty-three numbers under one account code.

Hundreds of numbers in the catalogue.

Maybe more behind the encrypted section.

“What if I want to keep going?”

Elias leaned back in the chair.

“Tell me what you want to know next.”

Zoe opened her mouth.

Nothing came out.

Why her?

Who were the others?

What did the route mean?

Was AC019 really Mac?

What had MONITOR actually watched?

What changed on Monday?

Was Jackie in here somewhere?

Too many questions.

She hated that the best reason to stop had come from her own head.

Then one question remained.

“Do you think the numbers are people?”

Elias took his time.

“I think they follow individual cases through different placements and moves. Yours does.”

“So people.”

"Probably."

"Kids?"

"Some. We know yours is. We don't know the rest."

That was enough.

Zoe stared at the rows.

The numbers did not become faces.

That would have been easier.

Faces made suffering belong to somebody.

Numbers meant someone had needed a system.

She thought of the room with too many chairs. The girl who had gone stiff when a man crouched beside her. The older children whispering rules. Jackie dividing food without noticing she did it.

Her own photograph.

Two plaits.

Laughing.

Zoe turned to a fresh page in the notebook.

"What are you writing?" Elias asked.

"A rule."

"For us?"

"For whoever ends up seeing this."

She wrote slowly:

DON'T USE THE KIDS TO PROVE WHAT THE ADULTS DID.

Elias read it and left the wording alone.

Underneath, Zoe added:

names addresses where they are

Then, after a gap:

use the adults

money

signatures

companies

She stopped at routes.

“Routes can lead to them,” she said.

“Then we don’t publish routes until we know what they point to.”

Zoe put a question mark beside the word.

She put the pen down.

* * *

They did not touch the encrypted volume.

They did not contact Voss or Vale.

Elias made the second copy while Zoe tried to read.

Another progress bar appeared.

She groaned.

Elias turned the laptop away.

“That’s manipulation.”

“Mercy.”

“Same sentence adults always use.”

He turned it back.

Estimated time: 2 hours 11 minutes.

Zoe stared at it.

“That was cruel.”

"You asked."

"I withdraw the complaint."

"Too late."

She lay back on the bed and held the paperback above her face.

For the first time all evening, she read three pages without checking the screen.

Shortly after midnight, Elias woke her as soon as the copy finished.

No argument this time.

The original went back into Zoe's backpack beneath the folder. The paperback slid in beside it.

Ordinary story.

Personal record.

Unknown archive.

All three fitted.

One copy stayed with Elias for the next stage of analysis. The second went into a plain padded envelope.

"Where does that go?" Zoe asked.

Elias told her his first idea.

She rejected it because the place was tied to one of his old identities.

She suggested another.

He rejected that because neither of them could check whether it stayed where they left it.

They argued quietly for several minutes.

The final plan belonged to neither of them.

Zoe liked that more than winning.

Elias wrote the location down, looked at what he had written, then tore

the paper into four pieces and dropped them into separate bins around the room.

Zoe stared.

"That seems dramatic."

"It had an address on it."

"You could've just not written it down."

Elias looked at the pieces. "Learning."

"Slowly."

They switched off the lamp. Traffic hissed beyond the wet window. Zoe lay beneath the hotel blanket with the backpack beside her bed. The notebook remained on the bedside table. She could no longer see the words, but she knew exactly where they were. A17-04221. MONITOR. RECOVER. EXCEPTION. For days she had been asking who wanted her and what they wanted her for. The drive had given her something else instead. A word that had been waiting beside her number for years. MONITOR. Then, on Monday, somebody had changed it. Zoe stared into the dark. What changed on Monday?